

ANI

DEMANDING JUSTICE Naga, Meitei and Nepali women demand release of six people allegedly abducted by Kuki militants, Imphal, May 18

their driver were killed in Kangpokpi.

The killings triggered outrage across the Kuki-Zo community. Kuki organisations blamed the Naga armed groups. Naga organisations denied it and demanded a probe. While responsibility remains disputed till now, retaliatory abductions followed at once. According to reports, 28 Kukis were taken from Senapati and adjoining areas, and 20 Nagas from Leilon Vaiphei village and nearby locations in Kangpokpi.

THE VIOLENT FALLOUT

On May 14, within 24 hours, 14 hostages from each side were freed after negotiations. But 14 Kukis and six Nagas stayed in captivity. Following this, Nagas in Kuki-majority areas moved to Naga regions, and Kukis in Naga areas relocated to Kuki areas. Relief camps came up to house the displaced. On May 17, the United Naga Council called an inter-district bandh along National Highway 2, citing the hostage crisis. It hit Kangpokpi hardest. Since 2023, the Imphal-Kangpokpi route has remained closed to Kukis and Meiteis, leaving NH-2 as the district's lifeline to Nagaland, Assam and the rest of the country. Food, fuel and medicines all travel along it.

With the highway choked, prices have soared. A sack of rice now costs nearly Rs 5,000 in Kangpokpi, a cooking gas cylinder more than Rs 5,000 and petrol Rs 230 a litre. Traders and leaders warn that if the blockade holds, Kangpokpi could run short of essentials within days. Stocks of grain, gas, fuel and medicines are dwindling.

A breakthrough seemed near on June 8, when the remaining 14 Kuki hostages were freed after 25 days. However, the hope collapsed the next day: security forces recovered six bodies of the missing Naga abductees near Leilon Vaiphei village.

Organisations from both sides condemned the deaths, but none agreed on who was to blame. Naga civil society rejects the claim that Naga groups carried out the May 13 killings. Pricilla Thiumai, president of the Naga Women Union, Manipur, asked how Naga militants could enter an area ringed by Kuki villages, strike and slip away unseen. She alleged the Kuki National Front-President (KNF-P) was behind attacks on Nagas and urged action against Kuki groups under the Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement. Leaders of Kuki Inpi, the apex social body of the tribal community, condemned the killing of the six Nagas. Thangminlen Kipgen, president of Kuki Inpi Sadar Hills, traced the conflict to the February altercation and alleged the involvement of the NSCN-IM and United Naga Defence Force (UNDF) in attacks on Kuki villages—claims that Naga groups deny.

The violence has revived the debate over the SoO armed groups. Rohan Kuki, representing the Kuki National Front (KNF) in the SoO Joint Monitoring Group, denies any role, saying the front's name surfaces whenever Nagas or Meiteis are attacked, and that such claims aim to derail peace talks with the central government.

The Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI), an influential Meitei body, reads the events more broadly. Spokesperson Shanta Nahakpam said the crisis cannot be separated from insurgency, territorial

Takeaways

- **A conflict once defined by Meiteis and Kukis has now drawn Nagas as well**
- **The Naga-Kuki confrontation has brought fresh violence, displacement, and economic hardship**
- **Ethnic mistrust now outpaces political and security responses**